

AI TOOLS FOR PERSONAL AND BUSINESS GROWTH

A Business Address to Southwest Nigerian Entrepreneurs

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Good morning, distinguished gentlemen. I want to start by asking a simple question. How many of you have argued in a WhatsApp group this week? Yes. All of you. And how many of you lost that argument because you did not have the facts at your fingertips? That is exactly why we are here today.

We are living in a time where knowledge is no longer the exclusive property of professors and consultants. A motorcycle spare parts dealer in Dugbe market, Ibadan, now has access to the same intelligence as a Harvard-trained business strategist — if he knows how to use the right tools. That is what AI has done. It has democratised expertise. And if you are a businessman in Southwest Nigeria today and you are not paying attention to this, your competitor already is.

What Is AI, Really?

Before we go anywhere, let me explain what we are actually talking about. Because the word "Artificial Intelligence" sounds very big, very foreign, very technical. But let me break it down to something every one of you already understands.

Your brain works by recognising patterns. When you have been in business for twenty years, you can look at a customer's face and know whether they are serious or just wasting your time. You can look at your sales for January and know whether February will be hard or easy. You are not doing complex mathematics in your head. You are recognising patterns from years of experience and stored data.

That is exactly what AI does. It is a system that has been trained on enormous amounts of data — text, images, sounds, numbers, conversations — and it has learned to recognise patterns in all of that data. When you ask ChatGPT a question, it is not thinking the way you think. It is recognising patterns in language. It has seen millions of questions and millions of answers, and it knows what a good answer to your specific question looks like based on those patterns.

When a bank's AI system flags a suspicious transaction on your account, it is because the AI has seen millions of transactions and learned the pattern of what fraud looks like. Your own transaction broke that pattern, so it raised an alert. When a supermarket's system automatically reorders stock, it is because the AI has learned the pattern of when a product runs low and how long restocking takes. It did not wait for a human to notice the shelf was

empty. It acted on the pattern.

This is what data is. Data is the raw material. Patterns are what you extract from data. And AI is the engine that finds patterns faster and more accurately than any human being ever could.

This means one thing for every businessman in this room: the more data you have about your business, your customers, and your operations, the more powerful AI becomes as a tool for you. If you have no data, AI cannot help you find patterns. If you have rich, structured data, AI becomes the most powerful analyst you have ever employed.

Everything I am about to say flows from this one foundation. Data is your most valuable business asset. Not your building. Not your fleet of vehicles. Your data.

The Tool You Already Have in Your Pocket

Many of you are already using Meta AI without knowing its full power. When you open WhatsApp and see that blue circle at the bottom, that is Meta AI. When you are in a group chat and someone is arguing about whether a particular government policy affects import duties, you can type "@Meta AI" directly in that group and ask for the facts. It will answer in the group, in real time, in front of everyone. You do not even need to open another app. Your argument is settled.

But Meta AI is more than a debate referee. You can speak to it. Literally hold your phone up and talk to it like you are talking to a knowledgeable friend. Ask it to help you write a message to a difficult customer. Ask it to summarise a long document someone sent you. Ask it to help you think through a business decision. It works on WhatsApp, on Facebook, on Instagram, and on Messenger. It is the same intelligence everywhere, and it works remarkably well even on Nigerian mobile data.

This is important because many of us are not comfortable typing long things on a phone. You do not have to. Just speak. The AI will understand you, respond to you, and help you. That alone should change your morning routine.

Your Personal Life, Upgraded

Before we talk about your business, let me talk about you as an individual. One of the biggest challenges for a businessman is that there is never enough time to learn. You want to understand the new tax regulations. You want to read about what is happening in your industry. You want to improve how you present yourself. But the day just runs away.

AI tools like ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini are like having a brilliant friend who has read everything. Imagine you want to understand the implications of the new Companies and Allied Matters Act amendment. Instead of paying a lawyer five hundred thousand naira for a consultation, you open ChatGPT and say, "Explain to me in plain English how the recent CAMA changes affect a small limited liability company in Nigeria." It will break it down for you clearly. You can ask follow-up questions. You can say, "Give me an example." It will keep going until you understand.

If you are preparing for a presentation, you can tell Claude, "I am speaking to a group of businessmen in Ibadan tomorrow. Help me structure my talking points on cash flow management." It gives you a full outline in minutes. You adjust it to your voice and your experience, and you walk into that room confident.

For those of you reading long reports, white papers, or PDF documents, there is a tool called NotebookLM from Google. You upload the document and ask it questions. You do not read two hundred pages. You ask, "What are the three main risks in this report?" and it tells you. A managing director in Lagos uses this to brief himself on investor documents in fifteen minutes.

Have you noticed that when you start typing an email on your phone, it begins to suggest the next words? That is a small version of AI. But it goes much deeper than that. There are AI systems today that can read all your previous emails, understand your communication style, understand how you typically respond to certain kinds of messages, and then draft full replies on your behalf. You review, you approve, you send. Or in some configurations, it sends automatically. Your inbox is managed. Your responses are consistent and professional. And you did not type a single word.

Marketing Your Business Without a Marketing Team

One of the biggest costs for an SME in Nigeria is marketing. You either pay an agency you cannot afford, or you post inconsistently on social media and hope for the best. AI has completely disrupted this.

Let us say you sell building materials in Sango Ota. You want to run a promotion for roofing sheets this dry season. You open Meta AI or ChatGPT and say, "Write me a Facebook ad for roofing sheet sales targeting building contractors and homeowners in Ogun State. Make it urgent and include a WhatsApp contact." Within thirty seconds you have a persuasive ad. Ask it for five versions. Pick the one you like. Post it.

Meta AI understands the Facebook and Instagram advertising ecosystem deeply. It can advise you on which hashtags are performing well in your industry, which regions to target your paid ads for the best return, and how to structure your creative so that the algorithm works in your favour.

For images, Canva AI generates professional marketing graphics even if you have never designed anything in your life. You type a description, it generates the image. You add your business name and phone number and post. No graphic designer. No waiting three days for a simple flyer.

Today, you can create a full advertisement video, a product demonstration video, a training video for your staff, or a documentary about your company — without a camera, without actors, without a production crew. Tools like Runway, Sora, Kling, and HeyGen allow you to generate video from nothing more than a text description or a script. You type, "Show a busy Nigerian supermarket with a smiling cashier and a family shopping for provisions," and the AI generates that video. You add your voiceover, your branding, your call to action — and you have a professional advertisement.

For the voiceover itself, ElevenLabs is extraordinary. You can clone your own voice. You record a few minutes of yourself speaking clearly, and ElevenLabs creates a digital clone of your voice. From that point on, you type whatever you want your voice to say, and it speaks it — in your voice, in your accent, with your tone. You can create radio advertisements, explainer videos, training materials, and telephone greeting systems all in your own voice without recording a single additional word.

For WhatsApp and broadcast marketing, platforms like Wati and ManyChat connect to your WhatsApp Business API and automate your customer campaigns. A fashion boutique in Ikeja sends new stock alerts to over two thousand customers every Friday, automatically, while the owner is in church.

Customer Service, Proposals, and Finance

Every one of you has lost a customer because nobody picked up the phone at 9pm. AI solves this. A WhatsApp chatbot answers your most common questions twenty-four hours a day. What are your prices? Where are you located? Do you deliver to Ibadan? What is your return policy? All answered instantly, automatically. Tools like Tidio, Respond.io, and Intercom make this possible without any coding knowledge.

For proposal writing — those of you who pursue contracts, government tenders, and corporate supply agreements — Claude, ChatGPT, and Jenni AI can help you write compelling, well-structured proposals in a fraction of the time it used to take. For research and citations, tools like Elicit, Consensus, and SciSpace find credible sources and generate references automatically.

On finance, AI tools now allow you to connect your accounting data and receive plain-language analysis. But the one I want every one of you to remember is AI for auditing. If you have staff handling money, if you have a payroll, if you run a store or a warehouse — run your bank statements against your internal financial records using AI regularly. A transport company owner in Ibadan discovered three years of systematic theft by a trusted accountant simply by running his statements through an AI comparison tool. The AI found patterns of small, regular discrepancies that human eyes would never have caught. Thirty-six months of theft. Found in forty minutes.

Your Website, Built Today

If your business does not have a website, your business does not exist to the generation that is now entering its peak spending years. Young professionals Google everything before they buy. Tools like Durable.co, Framer AI, and Hostinger's AI website builder generate a complete professional website from a single paragraph of text. You describe your business, the AI builds the site, you add your photos and contact details, and you publish. Done. Your business is now on the internet.

Recruitment and Human Resources

For those of you with growing teams, AI has transformed recruitment. You can now collect CVs, feed them into an AI system, and let it screen every application against your criteria — qualifications, experience, communication quality, relevance. The AI shortlists the strongest candidates without any human having to read a hundred CVs. Tools like Workable, Manatal, and customised ChatGPT workflows do this efficiently.

But here is what becomes possible over time. As you hire people and track their performance, the AI learns. Using machine learning, the system begins to understand what a successful employee in your specific business actually looks like. It adjusts its screening criteria based on who performed well and who did not. Your recruitment process becomes smarter with every hire. The system learns your business the way a seasoned HR manager would — except it never forgets and never gets tired.

Data: The Asset You Are Not Building

Every customer that walks through your door, calls your number, or sends you a WhatsApp message is a data point. Every sale, complaint, enquiry, and referral — data. And right now, most of you are letting that data disappear into your head, a jotter on your desk, and WhatsApp messages you will never find again.

The businesses that dominate the next ten years in Nigeria will be the ones collecting, storing, and analysing customer data today. Simple tools like KoboToolbox and Google Forms collect structured data even in areas with low connectivity. Airtable and Zoho CRM organise customer information properly. Google Looker Studio and Microsoft Power BI turn that data into visual dashboards that show you exactly what is happening in your business.

A school owner in Ogbomoso started collecting structured data on her students' parents — their occupations, their neighbourhoods, their communication preferences. Within one year she redesigned her fee payment structure, her communication strategy, and her school bus routes. Her retention rate went from sixty percent to eighty-nine percent. No advertising spend. Just data, intelligently used.

Digitise Everything First

Now I need to say something that underlies everything I have spoken about today. None of this works if your business is still running on paper, on memory, and on informal processes.

Before AI can help you, you must digitise. Every transaction must be recorded on a software platform. Who paid, how much they paid, when they paid, what they bought. Every staff attendance record. Every customer complaint. Every delivery. Every invoice. Your WhatsApp conversations, your emails, your purchase orders — all of it must live in a digital system that you own and can access.

If you cannot operate a computer yourself — and there is no shame in that — then employ someone who can. Every serious business today needs at least one person whose job is to manage the digital infrastructure of that business. Not just to post on Instagram. To manage your data, your systems, and your digital operations. This is not a luxury. It is the foundation without which everything else I have said today is inaccessible to you.

There are platforms today that allow you to build automation workflows — sequences of actions that happen automatically when a trigger occurs. A customer pays and an automated receipt is sent. A new enquiry comes in and it is automatically logged, categorised, and assigned to a staff member. A monthly report is automatically generated and sent to your email. Platforms like Zapier, Make, and n8n allow you to build these workflows without writing code.

For those of you with field staff, delivery teams, or sales representatives, GPS tracking through mobile apps allows you to know where your people are at every moment. Platforms like YardCode, built right here in Nigeria, provide geo-addressing and location intelligence specifically designed for our environment where conventional street addresses are unreliable.

When all of this is in place — when your business is digitised, your data is structured, your workflows are automated — then AI does not just answer your questions. It begins to see patterns in your business that you yourself have never noticed. Things that were invisible to you for years become visible the moment your data is clean and accessible.

Your Business Can Have an Entirely New Department Run by AI

With everything you have built — your years of experience, your operational procedures, your customer knowledge, your response patterns, your pricing logic, your brand voice — it is now

possible to create an entirely new department in your business that is staffed entirely by AI. Not robots walking around your office. But intelligent systems that handle an entire function of your business, end to end, without human involvement in the day-to-day operation.

A customer sends a message asking about your delivery timeline to Osogbo. The AI responds in your voice, with your pricing, with your actual availability, professionally and immediately — at 11pm on a Sunday. When it gets to payment, that process can be automated too. Nigeria's banks are now implementing open banking APIs — meaning your bank account can communicate directly with your business software. A customer makes payment. The bank's system notifies your platform automatically. Your platform confirms the payment, issues the receipt, triggers the dispatch instruction, and updates your inventory — all without you lifting a finger.

This is not tomorrow. This is available today. The question is not whether the technology exists. The question is whether you have the knowledge and the infrastructure to deploy it.

Some of you are thinking right now, "If I automate everything, what happens to my fifteen staff?" Here is the honest answer. Those fifteen staff, freed from repetitive administrative tasks, can focus on relationship-building, problem-solving, quality control, and growth activities that AI genuinely cannot do. Your business does not shrink. It scales. You handle ten times the volume with the same team.

The Future That Is Already Arriving

The most important development you need to understand is AI agents. An AI agent is not just a chatbot that answers questions. It is an AI system that acts. It makes decisions, takes steps, completes multi-stage tasks, and interacts with other systems on your behalf — without human involvement.

In the next five years, when someone wants to order from your business, it may not be a human being who contacts you. It will be their AI agent, acting on their behalf, contacting your AI agent, which represents your business. The two agents will negotiate, confirm the order, arrange payment, and schedule delivery — all without either the buyer or the seller being involved in the conversation at all.

This is why digitisation is not optional. It is the price of admission to the next economy. Your website must be structured so an AI agent can read it, understand your offerings, and transact with it. Your inventory, your pricing, your availability — all of it must be accessible in real time through digital systems.

Begin preparing for this today. Not by panicking. By taking the first step — which is to digitise your operations, collect your data, and build your digital infrastructure deliberately and consistently.

The businessman who does this today will be the one whose AI agent is closing deals at 3am while he is asleep. The one who does not will be wondering, five years from now, why his business dried up and he cannot explain it.

A Word on Ethics and Responsibility

AI is powerful, but it is not perfect. And because it is powerful, using it carelessly or irresponsibly can damage your business and harm the people you serve.

AI systems can be biased. If the data you trained your recruitment AI on reflected unfair patterns from your past decisions, it will replicate those unfair patterns going forward — and you will not even know it is happening. If your customer service AI is left completely unsupervised, it can give wrong information, make commitments you did not authorise, or handle a sensitive situation in a way that destroys a valuable relationship.

This means that adopting AI requires you to remain engaged. You do not simply switch it on and walk away. You review its decisions regularly. You audit its outputs. You create checkpoints where a human being evaluates what the AI has done and confirms that it is consistent with your values, your business standards, and your ethical responsibilities.

No AI system should be making final decisions about people — your customers, your staff, your partners — without human review. The AI advises. The AI recommends. The AI executes routine tasks. But the responsibility remains yours.

Calculated risk is what separates great businessmen from those who stand still. But calculated means you understand what you are doing, you monitor the results, and you are willing to intervene when necessary. Use AI boldly. Use it wisely. And never use it as an excuse to stop thinking.

Invest in Knowledge. Invest in People.

Some people ask me, "If I start learning AI, will I not lose focus on my business?" My answer is this: learning AI is investing in the future relevance of your business. Because the businessman who has automated processes will be taking thousands of customers simultaneously, with a lean team, at low cost. You, with your fifteen unautomated staff, will not be able to compete. Not because you are less hardworking. But because the playing field has changed.

You have two options. Learn enough about AI to direct it intelligently in your business. Or employ people who have that knowledge and can implement it on your behalf.

But here I must caution you: employing the wrong person to handle your AI and digital systems is worse than not employing anyone at all. A poorly implemented AI system can expose your customer data, make financial errors, give incorrect information at scale, or automate a bad process and make it run faster in the wrong direction. If you are going to bring AI into your business operations, bring in people who are genuinely trained for it.

At RAIN — Robotics and Artificial Intelligence Nigeria — we are doing exactly this work. We train individuals and organisations in artificial intelligence, machine learning, robotics, and data science. We run structured certificate programmes designed for the Nigerian context, for Nigerian businesses, with Nigerian examples. We are happy to work with this fellowship — as a group, as individual businesses, or as organisations — to build that capacity. And if you are looking to hire, our graduates are trained specifically for the kind of operational AI challenges you face every day. They are not theoretical. They are practical, deployable, and ready.

Gentlemen, the tools exist. They are affordable, many of them are free, and most of them work on the phones in your pockets right now.

Digitise your operations. Collect your data. Automate your processes. Deploy AI ethically and deliberately. Invest in knowledge — yours and your team's. And prepare your business for the agents that are coming.

Learn AI. Adopt AI. And do it now, while the advantage still belongs to the early movers.

God has placed us in the most consequential technological moment in human history. The question is not whether this moment will change Nigerian business. It will. The question is whether the businessmen in this room will be the ones leading that change — or the ones trying to catch up.

The choice is yours. Make it wisely.

Thank you.